Challenges in the Future for World Evangelization

Norway Christian Leadership Meeting

Luis Bush

May 1998

Introduction:

There are many new trends in missions in our day that represent challenges both as an institution educating new missionaries and as Christians in a modern civilization. We are living in a day of perhaps the most unprecedented activity of God in the history of the church. There are many changes, many paradigm shifts taking place as we approach the year 2000 and beyond. It is very difficult to highlight some of the trends to the exclusion of others.

When secular author John Naisbitt select ten mega trends in his bestselling book called “Mega Trends 2000,” it came out of an extensive process of reading newspapers, magazines from many sources, observing which subjects are repeated, compiling those into categories then prioritizing them into ten major trends.

Even secularist John Naisbitt admits we are living in a time of unprecedented global revival. In his follow-up to the 1982 bestseller, Megatrends, he writes about the tenth of the Megatrends from the previous book and calls his new book: "Religious Revival of the Third Millennium." In it he describes the "unmistakable signs of a worldwide multi-denominational religious revival."

The "God is dead" philosophy of the sixties is being quickly replaced. "With the millennium in sight, the powerful countertrend of the religious revival is repudiating blind faith in science and technology."

Huge increases have been experienced in church membership, especially among Evangelical, Charismatic and Pentecostal denominations. A "global phenomenon" is taking place that will replace modernism and a reliance on science; "the ideal of progress has given way to the return of faith."

While this may be difficult to see from a Norwegian, Scandinavian or European perspective it has become a global phenomenon, especially in the 10/40 Window.

The primary focus of the move of God, Satan and the church appears to be in relation to the 10/40 Window. Why the 10/40 Window? Because the core of the unreached people of our world live in this rectangular-shaped window! Often called "The Resistant Belt", the window

extends from West Africa to East Asia, from ten to forty degrees north of the equator. This specific region, which has increasingly become known as the 10/40 Window, encompasses the majority of the world's Muslims, Hindus, and Buddhists – literally billions of spiritually impoverished souls.

I. Challenges in the future for world evangelization as an institution educating new missionaries

A. Challenges in the future for world evangelization as an institution

1. Organizational renewal to focus on the unreached

Again, it was John Naisbitt who wrote in Megatrends 2000: "The year 2000 is operating like a powerful magnet on humanity, already reaching down into the 1990's and intensifying the decade. It is amplifying emotions, accelerating change, and heightening awareness, compelling us to re-examine ourselves, our values and our institutions…" The largest evangelical organization in the world in this last year exemplifies this new reality. They have totally restructured in these last years as we approach the year 2000 to focus on reaching the unreached peoples in the 10/40 Window. Beyond 2000 undoubtedly this trend will pick up. We are all being called to re-examine our structures. An example in Norway is the Norwegian Santal Mission, under Torbjorn Lied who also chairs the Norwegian Missionary Council, has encouraged the renewal of the mission to focus on the unfinished task.

2. Flexible leadership style to complete the unfinished task

From the current trend about effective organizational development emerges effective organizational development for the post 2000 AD world. Organizational development that grows in effectiveness in the nineties can be characterized by a series of contrasts. The flexible leadership style model emphasizes personal relationship over positional relationship. The focus of loyalty has shifted from institution to people. The style is less structured – more flexible. The source of energy rather than from stability comes instead from change and innovation. Instead of leadership being dogmatic, authoritative it is inspirational, empowering, enabling, facilitating. The leader rather than giving orders coaches, teaches. Instead of the quality depending on the affordable best it calls forth excellence. Expectations for associates are not for security but rather personal growth. Status does not come from title and rank but from making a difference. What are considered resources are not so

much cash and time but rather information, people and networks. This is the wave of the future—beyond 2000.

B. Challenges in the future for world evangelization as an institution educating new missionaries

Training missionaries for world evangelization has been done for hundreds of years. But never have so many leaders of major training institutions from around the world gathered in such great numbers to consider how they might learn from each other with the purpose of improving and partnering as in June 1997 in South Africa at GCOWE 97. There were some 15 leaders from Norway at GCOWE 97. There were ten mini-consultations within GCOWE 97 one of which was the Presidents and academic Deans of missionary training centers.

The motivation that drew over 250 Presidents & Academic Deans of the leading training institutions together in Pretoria, came from the challenge sounded by the AD2000 & Beyond Movement in the slogan, "A church for every people and the gospel for every person by the year 2000." That simple phrase captures the meaning of world evangelization in everyday language and adds a goal for finishing the task that Jesus Christ gave to his followers before His ascension.

"Dangerous People," was the phrase used by Dr. David Kim from Korea in his keynote address to the gathering. Presidents and Academic Deans of training institutions, by virtue of their influential positions, control much of the process and the pace of world evangelization. If Presidents and Deans have no vision or the wrong vision, then world evangelism suffers. They are dangerous. Without a personal vision they will have no vision to transfer to their missionary students. But if they catch a vision, the right vision, that fire will spread rapidly. He warned the participants against being diluted, sidetracked and losing vision. The danger is that scholars will see their task as training more scholars rather than training soldiers for the battle of winning souls and planting churches in every people group on earth.

"Tradition!" Throughout the gathering other scholars and missionary trainers addressed the Presidents and Academic Deans on understanding specific issues standing in the way of the spread of the gospel to every segment of the world. Much of our curriculum and training methods are ineffective today. Great political change has completely reshaped our world in the last few decades. The fall of the USSR and the rise of militant Islam, the emergence of China, anti-western sentiment, and the rapid advances in technology have brought total change to the "where" and the "how" that the Christian message can be spread.

Many of our training institutions are stuck in the traditions of the past generation. We have not changed with the times. Many of our institutions do not offer courses or training opportunities that adequately equip missionary students with the knowledge, character, or skills to become successful missionaries in today's world. The participants were reminded that no missionary will be successful with just knowledge and skills. Personal character and faith are often overlooked in the training process. Re-think curriculum, delivery systems and partnering strategies to train greater numbers of missionaries for the multi-faceted challenges they will face at the closing of this century.

The two hundred and fifty Presidents and Academic Deans (PAD) representing theological schools from 53 nations resolved to embrace and share the following theses:

1. The primacy of missiological concern for world evangelism must be recognized and focused in the total curriculum of ministry training.

2. Partnership at all levels and in multiple forms is essential for reaching the unreached people of the world.

3. Formal, non-formal and relational approaches to learning are to be seen as complementary rather than competitive.

4. The content of ministry training must uphold the uniqueness of Jesus Christ and the necessity of personal faith in Him as Lord and Savior. This is especially imperative in the light of the increasing pluralistic environment which has been brought about by the resurgence of non-Christian religions hostile to the advance of the gospel, by the erosion of historic Christianity in the West, and by the increasing prevalence of secularism almost everywhere.

5. Ministry training must aim to produce practicing super naturalists who minister effectively in the power of the Holy Spirit, relying on prayer and complete trust in the Word of God.

6. Basic to all ministry training is spiritual and character formation in the life of the student, in part facilitated by the example of teacher.

7. Approaches to ministry training must reflect concern for the whole counsel of God wisely contextualized and sustainable by local and national resources.

8. Serious consideration should be given to the training of both husband and wife for their mutual effectiveness in ministry, and accessibility to ministry training broadened to include all who can benefit from it.

Challenges in the future for world evangelization as Christians in a modern civilization. Get involved in the 10/40 Window as a primary focus. Why? There is a global mission focus on the 10/40 Window.

I. The Move of the Holy Spirit in the 10/40 Window

A. Open doors for the gospel

Paul wrote to the church in Colossae, "And pray for us, too, that God may open a door for our message, so that we may proclaim the mystery of Christ." (Col. 4:3).

Today the Holy Spirit is opening the doors in the 10/40 Window. One of the largest ministries in the Arab World. "Truly the Lord has amazed us with the unprecedented ways He has been working during this past few years, and especially in opening new doors for ministry and is there anything greater than a wide-open door for the proclamation of the gospel?"

In the Arabian Peninsula Saudi citizens have invested literally billions of dollars in the development of international satellite television. 70% of all homes by the end of 1997 have a dish and an estimated 90,000 new homes get their first satellite dish every month. All this even though satellite dishes are officially illegal in Saudi Arabia! Satellite television has become a wide-open door for the proclamation of the gospel in the Arab World. 1997 was the second year of operation for a major evangelical cooperative satellite initiative with broadcast hours rising from 2 hours a week to 9 hours per week by next month.

B. People are responding to the gospel in the 10/40 Window

In a ministry in Jordan it was reported this month that more than 65,000 have responded since they started advertising in different newspapers and magazines the offering to send for free a Bible. World attention remains focused on the "Holy Land" in their struggle for peace and possession of the Holy sites in Hebron, Nablus and Jerusalem. An even more dramatic and exciting observation captures the attention of Christian believers. Receptivity to the Gospel message of the saving power of God in Jesus Christ increased in the aftermath of the Gulf War. A long-term servant in the Holy Lands in his manuscript on what is happening in the region wrote: "Evangelical Christians from numerous churches and organizations mounted a concerted effort of "Praying through the 10-40 Window" … which included the majority of the Muslim world population. The Palestinian Authority, Jordan and other Middle East countries felt the impact of these prayers." For the first time in recent memory Muslims are beginning to accept the Gospel and the power of the written Word. They seek fellowship with Christians to learn how to pray and to worship

God in new ways. … Now, with the dawning of the twenty first century, the fire of the Holy Spirit breaks out again, fanned by the praise of numerous believers of all nationalities in assemblies, house churches and traditional churches all over…"

Global researchers have in recent years been tracking what they call "The geo-response rate to the gospel." How do you measure response? Take the number of converts to Christ each year in any particular people, country or ethnic group and divide it by the amount of evangelism they have had from all sources. When you do that you come to the surprising conclusion that in all the 10/40 Window Peoples this ratio is vastly higher than outside the Window. You ask how much more responsive. They are "100 times more responsive."

II. The Move of Satan in the 10/40 Window

The very name Satan means adversary. Satan's avowed purpose is to thwart the plan of God in every area and by every means possible. The Scripture makes this clear in 1 Pet. 5:8 "Your enemy the devil prowls around like a roaring lion looking for someone to devour." Satan blinds their minds so that they will not accept the gospel (2 Co 4:4). More Christians have died for their faith in this century than in all the previous history of Christendom combined. According to World Mission Digest there are some 100 million martyrs in this so called modern 20th Century. More people have died in circumstances related to their faith in this century than in all the 20th Century wars combined. The problem is getting worse rather than getting better.

Every indication is that Satan has moved in the world and especially in the 10/40 Window to oppose the advance of the Gospel. Christian Solidarity International is a global interdenominational organization which defends the human rights of persecuted Christians and other victims of repression. They have developed a map showing the countries with restricted human rights in colors on four levels. The darker the color the fewer human rights. For the three levels with the lowest level of human rights you will find all the countries in the 10/40 Window. Satan has established a stronghold in the 10/40 Window, but every indication is that this grip is loosening—but still it causes great affliction.

In the communist countries of China, North Korea and Vietnam and in the countries where the radical strains of Islam have influence, Christians are daily facing persecution and martyrdom. When we think of persecution, we are thinking about being beaten, raped, robbed, dispossessed, imprisoned unjustifiably, enslaved and killed. In speaking about persecution and discrimination we are talking primarily about 60 countries around the world. This is a serious global problem and unfortunately, a growing trend of our day. In Iran in May 1996 a new wave of persecution began and as a result pastors and Christians have

been arrested, interrogated and executed. Christians are forbidden to contact the outside world and ordered to constantly report to the Ministry of Information. Many Muslim converts have lost their jobs and are under heavy surveillance. In the West Bank and Gaza Muslim believers are suffering serious persecution currently.

As we look at the challenge, neither the Scriptures nor the reports from around the world suggest that things are going to improve but rather get worse. The Scripture describes a future scene in heaven in Rev. 12 7 “And there was war in heaven. Michael and his angels fought against the dragon, and the dragon and his angels fought back. 8 But he was not strong enough, and they lost their place in heaven. 9 The great dragon was hurled down—that ancient serpent called the devil, or Satan, who leads the whole world astray. He was hurled to the earth, and his angels with him.” Then verse 12 reads “He is filled with fury, because he knows that his time is short.”

III. The Move of the Church in the 10/40 Window

A. The prayer moves of the global church toward the 10/40 Window

The prayer for this region of the world has been amazing! With the hope of perhaps one million in October 1993 some 20 million Christians from 1200 local churches from different parts of the world prayed county by country through all the countries of the 10/40 Window. On-site intercessory teams came to each of the countries for days of prayer walking, asking God for a spiritual breakthrough to take place. Millions of others worldwide joined in the concerted prayer effort. In 1995, building upon the prayer momentum of 1993, prayer focused on the 100 gateway cities of the 10/40 Window. The commitment was beyond expectation as over 36 million were reported to have participated. Then in 1997 the focus moved to the unreached peoples of the 10/40 Window and again the commitment was so massive that written reports are still coming in. "Praying through the Window IV—Light the Window" in October 1999 may well be the most powerful and effective effort to date. When a well-respected international worker in the area commented that he anticipated a spiritual harvest in the Arab world soon, I asked him: "Why?" He answered: "Growing awareness and prayers of the saints around the world."

B. The people move of the global church toward the 10/40 Window

When we pray to the Lord of the Harvest to thrust out laborers to the harvest field sometime, He thrusts out the very ones who were praying that prayer. It appears that this is what is happening. Interest in short- and long-term teams to countries within the 10/40 Window, from others within the 10/40 Window and from outside have dramatically

increased. For example, in the Philippines they are consciously focusing on sending and supporting efforts into the 10/40 Window. Already they have 1000 missionaries, many focusing on the 10/40 window. As a result of their efforts one of the largest churches in the Arabian Peninsula is pastored by a Filipino. They are having a major impact in the country of Myanmar today.

Joshua Project 2000 is a global effort of the church to seek to establish a church planting effort of at least 100 people in every one of the peoples of the world over 10,000. The total population of these almost 2000 distinct people lie in the 10/40 Window. There have been three basic phases of Joshua Project 2000. Phase one was to determine a widely agreed-upon priority list of least evangelized ethno-linguistic peoples with populations greater than 10,000, less than 2% evangelical and less than 5% Christian adherent. The list has continually undergone refinement to emerging realities. Numerous Peoples have been removed from or added to this list as better information has given a clearer picture of their status. Phase two was to determine which of the groups on the list had a reported church-planting effort in their midst. After gathering nearly 30,000 pieces of information from 80 countries, the encouraging result was to find that there were about 800 of the approximately 2000 without a church planting effort. Through this process groups were that remained 'unclaimed' were identified. Unclaimed groups have no reported church planting effort in their midst and do not have a reported mission agency pledging church planting soon. Most of these were claimed in the course of the global consultation (GCOWE 97) held in South Africa last July. Now the third phase is being conducted to determine the status of the indigenous church among these Peoples. While step two measured exposure, this third step seeks to measure response; what is the result of the church planting efforts? The minimum goal of the Joshua Project is to see a pioneer church-planting movement resulting in 100 or more Christians in one or more reproducing fellowships. It is encouraging to see the progress and commitment of the global church toward planting the church among the unreached peoples of the 10/40 Window and beyond.

Conclusion:

The challenges in the future for world evangelization as an institution educating new missionaries and as Christians in a modern civilization are great. We are being called to evaluate the life of our institutions, for renewal, re-focus on the unfinished task and cooperate with a region of the world where God the mission task is moving forward despite great opposition.

We see the move of God the Holy Spirit in powerful ways in the 10/40 Window as a trend of our times. However, we also observe the move of Satan to oppose the advance of God in the 10/40 Window as a trend of our times. And third, we discern that the Church worldwide

is moving into the 10/40 Window with prayer, with people and with the process of working together in renewed organizations with a more flexible style of leadership.